

THE FAMILIES DIVERSIFY

Businesses evolve with increased competition in the tech badlands. And the quest for new money-making schemes is on

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The last story was our light hearted take on the cut-throat competition amongst tech companies. Of course none of the companies have Mafia ties (we hope, for our sake); it just made for a nice setting for storytelling. While conceptualising the story, we stumbled upon a nice mnemonic anagram in the title – MAFIA SAGAS – which just happens to comprise the first letters of each of the companies that shape today's technology landscape. Conspiracy theory? Maybe. Maybe not.

Now for the more realistic look at how these technology behemoths are trying to attract and keep your attention, we'll analyse the facts. What can't be disputed in today's age is that tech companies – like the mafioso gangsters – are trying hard to hunt for greener pastures, as an increasingly global marketplace gets squeeze-dried in the constant hunt for profits and adding positively to their bottom line. Like

any business – whether it's a family-driven bunch of goons engaging in nefarious activities or a Fortune 500 technology company – it's all about the money, power and control. It's great to be cool and funky, but if you're not a commercial success, if you don't rule as many aspects of your target's life as possible, you won't stay in business – as any street smart person will tell you. Some tech companies strive towards that ultimate goal through innovation, going ahead of the curve; while others don't try reinventing the wheel, instead focusing on optimising resources and efficiency. Let's try and gauge the pulse of the 10 big families in technology, and see what they're up to.

Microsoft

After being deposed of its lofty mantle, and getting behind the curve a bit, the Redmond giant's street cred is at its lowest ebb, its pride stung. While the company still rules supreme in the desktop market – despite disappointing sales of Surface RT and Windows 8 criticism – its lack of

significant inroads into the mobile sector is the major cause for concern. Windows Phone has been out and about for close to three years now, and far from challenging the might of iOS and Android, it still struggles to woo developers.

However, all's not lost for the technology veteran, as it looks to shift away from the good old licensing model (for software) by adopting cloud-based subscription options – just take a look at Microsoft Office 365 and you'll gaze into the crystal ball. In a post on Microsoft's Office blog, Clint Patterson, Director of Communications, Office, doesn't leave anything to imagination, "Like Adobe, we think subscription software-as-a-service is the future. The benefits to consumers are huge. Subscribers are always up-to-date." He concedes that the consumer's shift from packaged software to subscription services will take time. Is this fundamental shift in Microsoft's revenue stream progressive or premature? Read more here: <http://dg.it.in/16XpVIS>

With the resounding success of its Xbox division, and the unlikely unearthing of a